their own set of challenges. Older adults are more susceptible to shingles, which can cause itching alongside severe pain. They also become prone to abnormally dry skin, or xerosis, as sebum production and skin lipids decline and the protective skin barrier weakens. Menopausal women report a sensation akin to ants crawling on or beneath the skin, arising often from altered nerve sensations.

HOW AN ITCH CAN RUIN YOUR LIFE

You may think of itch as a harmless aberration of the skin, but for some people, it can dent their confidence. Twenty-seven-year-old Swati Sethi, a Pune-based homemaker, found herself itching around the neck and collarbone a few months before her wedding. She blamed the jewellery and the heat, but the itch kept returning and her skin gradually became dry, red and darker. Eventually, a dermatologist diagnosed it as eczema. "I became obsessed with how my neck would look in photographs," Sethi says. "I stopped enjoying fittings and functions because I was constantly checking whether the rash was visible."

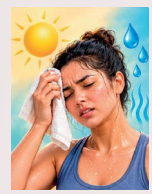
That kind of visibility can dent confidence quickly. "Acne itself can damage self-esteem," says Delhi-based psychologist Upasana Chadha, "but conditions such as fungal infections, scabies or eczema can be even harder socially because people may not understand what they are. The person starts worrying about how the skin looks and also about what others may assume. They may feel embarrassed, avoid photographs, stop wearing certain clothes or withdraw from social situations and intimacy. Over time, this can strongly affect self-esteem." Those with more widespread disease or rashes on the face were affected the most.

The median duration of fungal illness, as a 2026 study in *Cureus* of 2,776 adults across 325 dermatology centres in India noted, could go up to a year, and have a major effect on daily life. A 2023 study in the *Indian Journal of Dermatology, Venereology and Leprology*, analysing GBD data from 1990 to 2017, reported a 53.7 per cent increase in years lived with disability attributable to skin and subcutaneous diseases. By 2017, these conditions accounted for 4.02 per cent of all years lived with disability in India.

WHY WE ARE ITCHING MORE

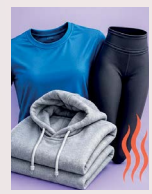
There is no single reason for rising complaints of itchy or irritated skin. Dermatologists point to a combination of environmental, lifestyle and skin-barrier factors

HEAT AND HUMIDITY



Sweating and persistent moisture encourage irritation and fungal growth, especially in skin folds

MORE OCCLUSIVE CLOTHING



Tight clothing and synthetic fabrics can trap heat and sweat and increase friction

OVER-CLEANSING



Frequent washing, harsh soaps, fragrant products can damage the skin's protective barrier

POLLUTION AND IRRITANTS



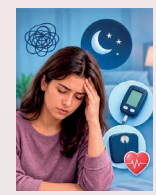
Air pollutants, dust, detergents and household chemicals can aggravate sensitive skin in some people

EXPOSURE TO ALLERGENS



Dust mites, mould, fragrances, cosmetics and certain fabrics can trigger, worsen dermatitis

LIFESTYLE AND HEALTH



Stress, poor sleep and conditions such as diabetes or obesity may lead to recurrent skin problems



"Used inappropriately, steroids can suppress the skin's local immune response. The rash may seem better for a while only to reappear"

—DR D.K. SHARMA, *Senior Consultant Dermatologist, Kailash Hospital, Noida*

MISUSE OF DRUGS

There is no relief as immediate as scratching. But none is as fleeting either. "Repeated scratching," says Dr Rajat Khandari, vice-president of the Indian Association of Dermatologists, Venereologists and Leprologists, "can damage the skin's protective barrier, intensify inflammation and trigger further itching, creating a vicious itch-scratch cycle."

Yet because itching is so commonplace, many people spend weeks trying home remedies, old prescriptions or over-the-counter medicines for relief. Steroid-containing creams have long been a popular choice because they quickly suppress redness, inflammation and itching. But the relief can be misleading. "While steroids can make the patient feel better, they do not kill